

Research Statement

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My research interests lie in the fields of the economics of education, public economics, and labor economics. I am particularly interested in the effectiveness of private versus public provision of services, such as education, and its implications for economic outcomes, welfare, and inequality. Both as subjects of interest and as tools for addressing these questions, I work with a broad range of applied econometric methods, including regression discontinuity designs, Empirical Bayes techniques, and discrete choice models. In addition, ongoing work involves survey design and primary data collection exploiting experimental and quasi-experimental variation. Below, I first summarize my current work before turning to my future research agenda.

“Schooling for Profit: Long-run Effects of Private Providers in Public Education” [JMP]

What should the government produce itself, and what should it outsource to private providers? This is a central question in a wide range of sectors, such as health care and education. In my job market paper, “Schooling for Profit: Long-run Effects of Private Providers in Public Education”, I study this type of outsourcing in the context of public education: specifically, by focusing on publicly funded for- and non-profit providers of high school education in Sweden.

Since the 1990s, privately managed charter schools operating entirely on equal public funding, and under the same rules as public schools, have expanded dramatically and now enroll nearly half of urban high school students. Using value-added and regression discontinuity methods, combined with population-wide register data, I find that for-profit schools cut costs on teachers at the expense of students’ long-run earnings. Non-profits, on the other hand, are as or even more effective than public schools. Despite this, for-profits have come to dominate the charter market, now enrolling more than a third of all students. To explain this puzzle, I show that students are largely unresponsive to schools’ earnings impacts. For-profits instead cater to student demand for other school features, such as attractive locations and study programs.

This paper provides rare empirical evidence on a fundamental tension in market-based education systems: satisfying student demand does not necessarily align with improving outcomes that policymakers value. This tension appears to be especially pronounced for for-profit providers. Despite being unusually permissive towards private providers, the Swedish system shares many features with prominent models of public education globally, including choice-based assignment, universal public funding and discretion in school management. As such, the insights from this study likely extend beyond the Swedish context.

Other research

In related work, I investigate the productivity of private versus public providers of pre- and primary schooling (“The Productivity of Public and Private Preschools (and Schools): Evidence from India” forthcoming in *The Economic Journal*, with Abhijeet Singh and Mauricio

Romero) and the limits of test-based accountability reforms (“Myths of Official Measurement: Limits to Test-Based Education Reforms with Weak Governance” in the *Journal of Public Economics*, with Abhijeet Singh) in India. These studies highlight the role of state capacity in explaining why education policies can produce sharply different outcomes in developing versus developed contexts. Despite the existence of a freely available public preschool option, whose expansion is part of the global Sustainable Development Goals, we document massively larger learning gains in private preschools. This weakness in public delivery extends to measurement: standardized test scores, a key tool in accountability policies, are themselves unreliable. Despite well-intentioned, we find evidence of widespread manipulation of official test scores in one of India’s largest standardized assessment programs, rendering them thoroughly uninformative about actual learning levels.

Future research

In the coming years, I aim to expand my research to better understand competition between schools. Studying competition necessarily involves defining the relevant market, which becomes particularly challenging if schools are differentiated on features other than, e.g., location. Building on the model of student demand used in my job market paper, I plan to simulate capacity changes in individual schools to estimate counterfactual student flows between all pairs of alternatives in the market. These flows provide empirical measures of both the *intensity* of competition and the *identity* of competitors faced by each school or provider. This framework will allow me to study a range of important questions: whether school quality responds to increased competition through entry and exit, how private and public providers differentiate themselves in order to soften competitive pressure, and how consolidation of providers—which has increased dramatically over the last decade in Sweden—affects the nature of competition.

My work together with Abhijeet Singh and Mauricio Romero also marks the beginning of a broader research agenda around preschool markets in developing countries. Data collection for a new project is currently underway. These data will allow us to identify individual preschool effects using admission lotteries, which would be the first of its kind in *any* preschool setting. In addition, information on parents’ preschool applications would also advance our understanding of preferences in the context of preschool education. Further, we are working on field experiments—such as hypothetical choice surveys—to provide additional sources of variation to study these questions.